



On innovation 論創新

What about the ability to innovate in China?

In fairness, innovation efforts in China in recent years have been breath taking with the growth in innovation labs and the encouragement by the Central Government for business enterprise to search for innovative solutions. It is clearly a cornerstone of the economy for business growth and development. What might help and accelerate this key functioning is the constant coaching of this process with profound understanding of the necessary culture in order to support innovation within any organization.

For example, in Israel you see that companies are constantly coming up with novel products. It's a 24-hour, 360-degree challenge and opportunity for the growing economy. And whether it is about developing security systems in Israel or games in Taiwan or new technologies

in the San Francisco Bay Area, we must be reminded that the choice is crystal clear: innovate or die.

Simply stated, the challenge for China is its ability to innovate in this next decade as it is becoming more predictable as more and more Chinese Brands become household names.

The thinking in Israel is entirely different. Their starting point is, "We are surrounded. We've got to innovate to survive." Clearly it's about courage, risk and taking initiative. You only have to look at how many Israeli companies are now listed on the NASDAQ exchange. But it all starts with leadership, the way management and decision-making takes place and the time it takes to get things done coupled with the additional time to market. The Israeli culture supports innovation, competitiveness and internal collaboration. Perhaps there is a lesson here for all of us to learn from?

How does that relate to the ability to innovate in Hong Kong?

In any sector in Hong Kong on any given day, one can hear people saying, "I am only a small potato" or, "I can't tell Big Boss what I really think."

Typically, innovative ideas are going to be filtered by more senior staff, then reviewed by senior executives with unnecessary intervention by protective administrative staff. It then goes up for scrutiny by a Director and if the Director doesn't have a good relationship with another Director or Secretary, then "POOF" – there goes your idea up in smoke.

Take the example of a train. A single locomotive pulls an entire train of carriages and in Hong Kong they all follow behind one locomotive. In the Israeli model, everyone has their own locomotive and are all pulling together. Of course, in any organization there has to be formal and informal organizational structures, but in terms of involvement it becomes a culture and a passion at an individual level for all to be encouraged to participate. Hence, those organizations that operate mostly within a political frame obviously do not have the same results as those focused to operate in the "outcome" frame.

中國創新能力如何？

平心而言，中國的創新領域近年來取得驚人的發展，這有賴中央政府鼓勵創新實驗室發展，為企業尋找創新方案，亦顯然是經濟增長和發展的基石。在深入了解文化的基礎上，籍著持續推動此過程支持不同組織內部的創新，將有助加速創新這關鍵要素。

比如說，以色列的企業總是在推出新產品。對發展經濟而言，這是全方位全天候的機會。無論是研發以色列的安全系統、台灣的電子遊戲或三藩市灣區的新科技，我們均須提醒自己眼前的選擇是極為明確的——要麼創新，要麼被淘汰。

未來10年，隨著更多中國品牌成為家喻戶曉的名字，中國的創新能力會變得愈來愈容易預測。簡而言之，中國所面對的挑戰，在於其如何創新。

在這議題上，以色列的思維則完全不同。以色列的出發點，是「我們被鄰國包圍，必須創新才能生存」。這顯然關乎勇氣、風險及採取主動的問題——君不見以色列有多少企業在美國納斯達克交易所上市？凡此種種，均源於領導管理層面，即管理和決策的方式、完成項目所需的時間，以及營銷產品所需的額外時間。以色列文化支持創新、競爭力和內部合作。這對我們而言，豈不值得學習？

這與香港的創新能力有何關係？

在香港企業的任何部門，每天總有人說「我們只是微不足道的小僱員而已」，或「我不能將自己的真實想法告訴大老闆」云云。

在大多數情況下，創意靈感總是首先經過資深員工過濾，再由傾向過度保護的行政人員審查，然後是高級行政人員審視，最後才送達主管審閱。如果該主管與其它主管或秘書的關係欠佳，創意靈感將到此為止。

以列車為例，所有車廂總是由最前方的機車拉動，這正是香港的情況。以色列的模式，是讓個人擁有自己的機車，然後匯集在一起。當然，任何組織均須設有正式和非正式的架構，但在參與方面，以色列的模式鼓勵個人參與，從而在個人層面轉化為文化及激情。因此，就成果而言，在政治框架內運作的組織，總是不及以「成績」為主導的組織。